Muslim Empires: Reading

World History · Unit 2 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Ottoman Summary, Safavid Art Search and Taj Mahal video sheet

Name: _____

Three Muslim Empires

Between about 1300 and 1700, three powerful Muslim empires ruled much of Asia, the Middle East, North Africa and southeastern Europe: the Ottomans, the Safavids and the Mughals. Historians call them 'gunpowder empires' because cannons and guns helped them conquer and defend land.

The Ottoman Turks captured Constantinople in 1453 after Sultan Mehmed II used giant cannons to break its walls. The city became Istanbul, the Ottoman capital. Sultan Suleiman (1520-1566) expanded the empire and organized a single legal code, so he was called 'the Lawgiver.' His janissaries, an elite army loyal only to the sultan, made the Ottomans feared. Christians and Jews could keep their faith if they paid a tax.

The Safavids ruled Persia (modern Iran). Unlike the Sunni Ottomans, the Safavids were Shi'a Muslims, and the two empires often fought. Shah Abbas made Isfahan a showcase of mosques, gardens and art. Safavid artists were famous for manuscripts, tiles and hand-knotted Persian rugs filled with symbols.

The Mughals ruled India. Akbar allowed people of all religions to serve in government and blended Hindu and Muslim traditions. His grandson Shah Jahan built the Taj Mahal as a tomb for his wife Mumtaz Mahal, but its huge cost weakened the empire. When different peoples meet through trade, conquest or migration, they share ideas, art and food. This is called cultural blending.

Check your reading

1. Why are these called 'gunpowder empires'?

2. What was one difference between the Ottomans and the Safavids?

3. Give one example of cultural blending in the Mughal Empire.